GROWTH BLUEPRINT ADVISORY

Industry & Manufacturing

The Saudi market-entry brief

THE SECTOR IN PLAIN WORDS

Before we start

Saudi Arabia wants to make more of what it uses and sells, and it has put real policy and funding behind that goal. For manufacturers, that opens doors: sites, financing support, incentives and customers who would like to buy locally. It also comes with expectations about local content, jobs and capability.

This brief is for manufacturers and industrial investors weighing a plant, an assembly line, a joint venture or a licensing arrangement. It explains the order of work that tends to save the most time, and where first-time investors usually lose months.

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Please note. This brief is general guidance written by advisers. It is not legal, tax or investment advice. Rules and programmes change, so confirm current requirements with the relevant authority and licensed advisers before you act. We do not include market-size statistics because they date quickly; ask us for current figures.

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What is driving demand

National industrial strategy

Policy supports local manufacturing across several priority sectors, with programmes designed to help investors.

Local content expectations

Large buyers and public bodies increasingly consider local content, which favours suppliers who produce in the Kingdom.

Proximity to growing demand

A large domestic market and access to the wider region support the case for local production.

Energy and feedstock advantages

Some industries benefit from access to competitively priced energy and raw materials.

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How the market is organised

The market at a glance.

Who is investing	Local industrial groups, global manufacturers, joint ventures and government-linked investors.
Where plants go	Industrial cities and zones with ready infrastructure, plus sector clusters near feedstock or customers.
What helps	Financing options, incentive programmes, utilities, and demand from large buyers who prefer local suppliers.
What decides success	Site and utilities, skilled labour, supply chain, and how well your product fits local demand.
Typical first move	A feasibility study with two or three site options and a partner conversation, before committing capital.

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Ways in

Greenfield plant

Build from scratch on a chosen site. Most control, longest timeline and highest capital.

Joint venture with a local partner

Combine your technology with a partner's relationships, land or capital. Governance is the key.

Acquire or partner with an existing facility

Faster, but requires careful diligence on assets, people and compliance.

Licensing or contract manufacturing

Lower capital, lower control. A good way to test the market first.

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Rules to check early

Confirm these early, with the relevant authority and a licensed adviser.

- [ ] Industrial licensing requirements and the approvals needed for your activity and site.
- [ ] Location rules, including industrial city allocation, utilities and environmental approvals.
- [ ] Product standards and conformity assessment for goods you make or import.
- [ ] Localisation and workforce expectations, including skills and training commitments.
- [ ] Customs treatment for equipment and raw materials, and any incentives, which have eligibility conditions.

06

Partners: who you will meet

Industrial city and zone authorities

They control land, utilities and many practical approvals. Start the conversation early.

Development financing bodies

Can support eligible projects, but expect a thorough review.

Engineering and construction contractors

Capacity and experience with your plant type matter more than price alone.

Local suppliers and logistics providers

Reliable inputs and transport make or break your economics.

07

Where people go wrong

Choosing the site before the supply chain

A good plot with poor access to inputs or customers is a costly mistake.

Underestimating utilities lead time

Power, water and gas connections can take longer than the building.

Counting on incentives you have not confirmed

Eligibility and timing should be checked before they appear in your model.

Thin skilled-labour plan

Recruiting and training technicians should start well before commissioning.

No plan for ramp-up

First-year output is often well below nameplate capacity.

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Your first 90 days

Days 1 to 30: frame

- Define product, capacity and customers for the first phase.
- Shortlist two or three site options and request utility details.
- Speak with authorities and with two manufacturers already operating here.

Days 31 to 60: test

- Run a feasibility model with realistic ramp-up and downside cases.
- Explore financing and incentive eligibility in writing.
- Meet potential partners and local suppliers.

Days 61 to 90: decide

- Choose a site and structure, with legal and tax advice.
- Draft a phased investment plan with go/no-go gates.
- Start the licensing and approvals timeline.

09

Questions to ask before you commit

Take these into your next meeting. If you cannot answer one, that is your next piece of homework.

- [ ] Who will buy what we make, and what do they need from us?
- [ ] Which inputs can we source locally, and at what quality and price?
- [ ] How long do utilities, licences and construction take in total?
- [ ] Which incentives could apply, and what must be true to qualify?
- [ ] What skills do we need, and how will we recruit and train them?
- [ ] What is our plan if ramp-up is slower than modelled?
- [ ] How do we structure a partnership so that decisions are quick?
- [ ] What are the gates at which we could pause or stop?

ملخص بالعربية

الصناعة والتصنيع: موجز دخول السوق السعودي

يشرح هذا الموجز كيف تفكر الجهات الصناعية في السعودية، وما الذي يلزم لتأسيس مصنع أو خط إنتاج أو شراكة صناعية. ستجد فيه ترتيبًا للعمل يوفر أكبر قدر من الوقت: تحديد المنتج والعملاء أولًا، ثم الموقع والمرافق والتراخيص والحوافز، ثم الكفاءات الفنية وسلسلة الإمداد. وننبه إلى أخطاء شائعة مثل اختيار الموقع قبل سلسلة الإمداد، والاعتماد على حوافز غير مؤكدة، وإهمال مدة توصيل المرافق. ابدأ بدراسة جدوى وخيارين أو ثلاثة للموقع قبل أي التزام.

هذا الموجز إرشاد عام كتبه مستشارون، وليس مشورة قانونية أو ضريبية أو استثمارية. تتغير الأنظمة والبرامج، فتأكد دائمًا من المتطلبات الحالية مع الجهة المختصة ومستشارين مرخّصين.